The shop only accepted WeChat payments or Alipay or other equivalents. I had read about Chinese fintech and the spread of online payments but had dismissed them as state propaganda and popular hype – much as, years before, I had laughed at the idea of buying a smartphone. The truth was that it was not propaganda or hype but rather a street reality in Xi'an. In the end, awkwardly and with due apologies, I left empty-handed. The stall owner, much less twinkly-eyed by then, waved me out of her store grumbling at the 'Xinjiapo' – Singapore – hick who was making her re-shelve a basket of unsold souvenirs.

Conclusion

India and China are far apart on power. The most visible and basic difference is in economic power, where the GDP gap is nearly $12 trillion. The second area of asymmetry is in soft power, the power of attraction. Here too, though more difficult to measure, the gap is substantial. Surprisingly, in military terms, the difference between the two powers, given geography and strategy, is not as large as the raw numbers might suggest. Leaving aside the question of why and whether China would choose to attack India, the Chinese military will find that the Himalaya and the Indian Ocean as well as Indian defensive options constitute a major limitation.

Power differences, as suggested earlier, matter. India as the weaker power is unwilling to make concessions. It does not want to further embolden China. China as the stronger power is also unwilling to make concessions. It does not see why it should do so given its strength. Shyam Saran, the former Indian foreign secretary and former chairman of the National Security Advisory Board who has served in China, in an interview in October 2020 had this judgement on the implications of the power gap: 'Today they [the Chinese] feel, "Why should we give anything?" You know, "We are so powerful, the other side has to accept what we are trying to say."'[40] In 2010, in a revealing moment, the Chinese foreign minister, Yang